

Handle Success Like You Handle Failure: Treating Success with the Same Respect as Failure, featuring Greg Hiebert

Greg Hiebert, Leadership Coach & Managing Partner

In 1996, the Lady Vols won the national championship, and, by all outward appearances, they were poised to do the same in the 1997 season. But nothing came easy for the Lady Vols that year, and many wondered not only if they would not make it to the Final Four, but whether they would make the tournament at all. After a soul-crushing loss to UConn in the regular season, Pat addressed the team and reminded them they must handle the loss.

Coach Pat Summitt

All right, everybody, get your heads up. We've got to handle this. We talked about handling success and now we're in a position we don't want to be in. We're having to handle failure.

Greg Hiebert, Leadership Coach & Managing Partner

While everyone would rather handle success, you must be equally prepared to handle failure – and not only handle it but come back from it.

Of course, the Tennessee Lady Vols are not the only team, organization, or collection of individuals who've had to come back from failure. Probably the greatest example of how failure has facilitated great success was in the life of Abraham Lincoln, certainly one of our most respected leaders in American history. Born into poverty, Lincoln was faced with multiple failures throughout his life. He lost eight elections, twice failed in business, endured the loss of loved ones, and led America through its darkest time as a nation. Many believe that it was Lincoln's ability to learn from failure that enabled him to be the leader America needed at such a difficult time in our history.

Jamie Holmes, the author of *Nonsense: The Power of Not Knowing*, suggests that you look at any success you encounter in the same way you look at failure. Otherwise, you might miss out on taking new risks that could lead to even greater success. Consider Steve Jobs' decision to launch what would become the iPad. Jobs and others at Apple were undoubtedly concerned about plunging ahead with the iPad because of the failure of Apple's Newton tablet in the 1990s. In a brilliant move, they recognized that, given the existing smartphone market, a touch phone would be more strategic to launch first. This would be the perfect vehicle for Apple to learn about and perfect touch devices. So, you guessed it. Apple went on to market the iPhone first, and after learning all the lessons that came with developing the iPhone, Apple was poised to then release the iPad.

This example points to a better model for learning, one in which failure and success are on equal footing and both trigger further investigation that help us revise our assumptions, models, and theories. I'd ask you to consider, to look back on your journey, and to see and reflect on how failure has shaped who you are today.